INCOMPLETE. Covered: official vs vendor adoption figures (US, UK, EU), survey-method comparison, depth of use, barriers from official surveys, micro-firm adoption. Added in the gap-fill pass (section 4b and section 9, all from search extracts): the OECD 2025 SME survey; the widening Eurostat size gap; SMB AI spending data (lender, card and vendor data, plus agency price lists as weak evidence); MSP surveys on who implements; the Kenya RCT. Section 9b states plainly that no credible SMB abandonment rate exists. Still missing: an official or independent measure of SMB implementation cost; any SMB abandonment rate with a stated method; an independent, numbers-backed case study of a 10-person firm with a shared human-agent context (only vendor cases found); the JPMorganChase Institute spending figures (unlocated); Intuit QuickBooks, Constant Contact and Microsoft/LinkedIn SMB surveys; the DSIT 2026 micro-firm figures. Reason: in this session WebFetch and curl were blocked for every source host tried (census.gov, federalreserve.gov, ec.europa.eu, ons.gov.uk, gov.uk, oecd.org, salesforce.com, uschamber.com, nfib.com and others: proxy 403 / DNS refusal), and the shared web-search budget (200 calls across all agents) ran out partway through. **Every figure below comes from search-engine result summaries of the named pages. None was read on the page itself.** Treat each one as "re-verify before citing". No verbatim quotes are given, because no page could be fetched.

Track 2: SMB

Last updated: 2026-11-06. Labels: EVIDENCE = measured/primary data; FORECAST = projection; OPINION = argument, vendor or consultancy view.

Verification note (added 2026-11-06): page fetches were blocked for most hosts this session, so findings marked search summary, search extract or snippet rest on search-engine extracts of the cited URL. Quotation marks inside findings mark wording as reported by that source; only quotes in this file's "Verbatim quotes" section (and in 13-quotes.md) were checked against a fetched page. Corrections from the verification pass are in verification.md.

Summary (5-8 bullets, the things that matter most)

- **"How many small businesses use AI" depends on who you ask and how you phrase it. Answers run from about 14% to 76%.** Official random-sample surveys put use at about 14% to 35%: US Census BTOS about 18-24% of all firms, UK DSIT 2025 14% of micro firms, ONS 28% of 0-9 employee firms, Eurostat 17% of small firms. Surveys that draw on membership lists land between: NFIB 24% of small employers. So do the Fed's own small-business survey (46% of employer firms) and the US Chamber (58% use generative AI). Vendor and program panels land highest: Thryv 55%, Goldman Sachs 10,000 Small Businesses 68-76%, Salesforce 75% "experimenting or implemented".
- **The US official series moved because the question changed, not because firms changed.** On 17 November 2025 Census replaced "AI used in producing goods or services" with "AI used in any business function". Measured use roughly doubled, from about 10% to about 17% (St Louis Fed figures, confirmed in the verification pass; earlier drafts said 9% to 18%). Any "SMB AI adoption doubled" headline that bridges late 2025 is mostly a wording artefact.
- **Breadth is rising and depth is not.** In the Fed's employer-firm survey (fieldwork Sep-Nov 2025), about half of AI users said they were "experimenting", 44% "partially integrated" and 7% "fully integrated". Across all employer firms that is roughly 3% fully integrated. ONS (July 2026) found UK adoption among firms with 10+ staff roughly tripled since 2023, while its depth proxy (AI technologies per firm) barely moved.

- **The barriers in official data cut against the thesis.** When official surveys ask why firms don't use AI, the top answers are "can't identify a use case", "not applicable to my business" and "prefer not to". Missing documented workflows or shared context barely appear. In the Fed survey, a third of employer firms had no plans to use AI. Of those, over half said it was not applicable and 30% said they would rather not use it.
- **Micro firms are not as far behind as the size gradient suggests.** ONS June 2026: 28% of 0-9 employee firms vs 29% of all firms. A Fed staff note (April 2026) says the smallest firms adopt more than size alone would predict. NFIB still finds a steep gradient: 21% of firms under 10 employees vs 48% over 50. Eurostat's headline series leaves out firms under 10 employees entirely.
- **SMB "adoption" mostly means buying ready-made tools, not building.** Scottish BICS data say most adopting firms bought external or ready-to-use AI software. NFIB's examples of AI are ChatGPT, Copilot, Grammarly and Canva. For most SMBs, the "implementation project" the thesis has in mind does not happen.
- **What SMBs spend, who helps them, and what fails (gap-fill pass, weak sources).** Lender, card and vendor data put average SMB AI spend at roughly £100-£300 (or €160) a month, mostly subscriptions. Agency quotes for bespoke automation ($1,500-$25,000 upfront) sit far above what almost any survey respondent reports spending. MSPs, the channel SMBs lean on, see AI as clients' top need (48%) but few earn meaningful AI revenue (13%), and only about half feel ready to guide SMBs. No credible SMB AI abandonment rate exists. The only RCT (Kenya, n=640) found no average gain: AI advice helped strong owners and hurt weak ones.
- **Reported impact on headcount is close to zero so far.** NFIB: 98% of small employers using AI saw no change in employee numbers. ONS BICS, late December 2025: 4% of AI-using UK firms reported lower headcount because of AI. NBER w34836 (about 6,000 executives in four countries): more than 80% report no effect yet on employment or productivity.

Key findings

1. Official statistics: United States (Census BTOS)

- **[EVIDENCE]** The Census Business Trends and Outlook Survey (BTOS) changed its core AI question with effect from 17 November 2025. The new wording replaced the old from 4 December 2025, per Census's "AI Question Wording Updates" document. The old wording asked whether the firm used AI "in producing goods or services". The new wording asks whether it used AI in any business function in the last two weeks, with examples (machine learning, natural language processing, virtual agents, voice recognition). Census notes a level shift at the change. Census, "AI Question Wording Updates" (PDF, late 2025). https://www.census.gov/hfp/btos/downloads/AI%20Question%20Wording%20Updates.pdf (seen via search summary only)
- **[EVIDENCE]** Before the change, BTOS AI use ran between roughly 3% and 9% of US firms for about two and a half years. In the first post-shutdown release under the new wording, it was about 17-18%. Ramp economist Ara Kharazian reports this and says a Census economist involved with the survey opposed the change because it breaks the 2023-2025 trend. Ramp AI Index, 14 January 2026. https://ramp.com/data/ai-index-january-2026 (search summary only. The Census-economist remark is second-hand via Ramp.)
- **[EVIDENCE]** Under the broader wording, national business AI use was 17.3% as of late 2025 (cited by the Economic Innovation Group and others). A Federal Reserve staff FEDS Note puts adoption at about 18% at year-end 2025. It also flags that the November 2025 broadening

affects comparisons over time. FEDS Notes, "Monitoring AI Adoption in the U.S. Economy", 3 April 2026. https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/monitoring-ai-adoption-in-the-u-s-economy-20260403.html (search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE]** In a May 2026 story covering 14 December 2025 to 3 May 2026, Census reported national AI use of about 19.8% for the period ending 3 May 2026. Use rose among firms with 20+ employees over that period but "did not change significantly" among firms with fewer than 20. For firms with 1-4 employees, Census publishes the rate as a ceiling ("less than 20%") rather than a point estimate. Census Bureau, "Large Firms With at Least 20 Employees Biggest AI Users", May 2026. https://census.gov/library/stories/2026/05/ai-use-businesses.html (search summary and a syndicated copy at https://morriscountyedc.org/large-firms-with-at-least-20-employees-biggest-ai-users/)
- **[EVIDENCE, unverified]** Secondary trackers report later BTOS readings of about 23-24% (August to early September 2026). I could not tie these to a Census release. One appears in the iFeelTech tracker https://ifeeltech.com/tools/business-ai-adoption-index. Do not cite until checked against census.gov/hfp/btos.
- **[EVIDENCE]** Census working paper CES-WP-26-25 (Bonney, Breaux, Dinlersoz, April 2026), "The Microstructure of AI Diffusion", uses BTOS to separate firm-level use, use across business functions and worker-task use. It is the right primary source for depth of use inside US firms. Not read this session. https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2026/adrm/CES-WP-26-25.html
- **[EVIDENCE, misreport flag]** A selfemployed.com article titled "Census Data Shows Smallest Firms Leading Small-Business AI Adoption" pegs itself to the April 2026 BTOS release. The search summary shows it quoting a 1-4 employee rate "rising from 4.6% to 5.8%". Those are the figures in a December 2024 Census blog on the old question series (https://www.census.gov/newsroom/blogs/research-matters/2024/12/ai-use-small-businesses.html). If the summary is accurate, the article recycles 2024 old-wording figures as 2026 news. https://www.selfemployed.com/news/census-btos-ai-small-business-adoption-2026/ (not verified on page)

2. Official and quasi-official statistics: Federal Reserve surveys of small firms

- **[EVIDENCE]** Federal Reserve Small Business Credit Survey (SBCS), "2026 Report on Employer Firms" (published March 2026, fieldwork September to November 2025, firms with fewer than 500 employees):
    - 46% of employer firms said the business or its employees currently use AI, and another 15% planned to within 12 months.
    - Among users: about half "experimenting", 44% "partially integrated", 7% "fully integrated".
    - 71% of users said AI raised productivity.
    - About one-third had no plans to use AI. Of those, over half said it was not applicable to their business and 30% said they prefer not to use it.

  https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/2026-report-on-employer-firms and PDF https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/-/media/project/clevelandfedtenant/fsbsite/reports/2026/2026-report-on-employer-firms/2026-report-on-employer-firms.pdf (search summary only).

Governor Lisa Cook cited the 71% productivity figure on 24 June 2026: https://www.federalreserve.gov/newsevents/speech/cook20260624a.htm

    - Method caveat: the SBCS is a convenience sample recruited through Reserve Banks' partner organisations, then weighted. It is not a random draw from a business register. This is from prior knowledge of SBCS methodology and was not re-checked this session.

- **[EVIDENCE]** The San Francisco Fed presented the SBCS on a different base. Counting employer and non-employer firms together, about 60% were using AI or planning to. The base differs from the 46% above, so the two figures should not be compared. SF Fed, "Small Business and AI: Understanding Adoption and Building Support Systems", May 2026. https://www.frbsf.org/community-development/initiatives/economic-development-small-business/community-economics-project (search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE]** A Fed staff FEDS Note reports that AI adoption among the smallest firms is stronger than size alone would predict. 3 April 2026. https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/monitoring-ai-adoption-in-the-u-s-economy-20260403.html (search summary only)

3. Official statistics: United Kingdom

- **[EVIDENCE]** ONS, "Artificial intelligence in UK businesses: 2023 to 2026" (released 20 July 2026, BICS data):

    - Self-reported AI use among firms with 10+ employees rose from about 12% in late 2023 to about 35% by mid-2026.
    - ONS tracks AI technologies per business as a proxy for intensity. Coverage reports this "barely moved". TNW puts the average adopter at 1.6 AI tools, a figure I could not confirm in the ONS tables.

  https://www.ons.gov.uk/businessindustryandtrade/business/businessservices/articles/artificialintelligenceinukbusinesses/2023to2026 ; TechMarketView, "UK AI adoption has tripled since 2023 but barely deepened", 21 July 2026 https://www.techmarketview.com/news/archive/2026/07/21/ukhotviewsextra-uk-ai-adoption-has-tripled-since-2023-but-barely-deepened ; TNW https://thenextweb.com/news/uk-ai-adoption-widening-not-deepening-ons-2026 (all search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE]** In the June 2026 BICS wave (fieldwork 15-28 June 2026), 29% of UK businesses used at least one AI technology, up 8 points on June 2025. By size: 28% of firms with 0-9 employees, 49% of firms with 250+. The 2 April 2026 bulletin gave 45% for 250+ in late March 2026. Same ONS article as above, plus https://www.ons.gov.uk/businessindustryandtrade/business/businessservices/bulletins/businessinsightsandimpactontheukeconomy/2april2026 (search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE]** In late December 2025, 4% of UK businesses using AI said their overall headcount had fallen as a result. ONS, "Business insights and impact on the UK economy: 8 January 2026". https://www.ons.gov.uk/businessindustryandtrade/business/businessservices/bulletins/businessinsightsandimpactontheukeconomy/8january2026 (attribution to this bulletin is probable but inferred from a search summary)

- **[EVIDENCE]** The most common barriers UK firms reported in 2023 were difficulty identifying activities or business use cases (39%), cost (21%) and AI expertise and skills (16%). ONS, "Management practices and the adoption of technology and artificial intelligence in UK firms:

2023", 24 March 2025. https://www.ons.gov.uk/economy/economicoutputandproductivity/productivitymeasures/articles/managementpracticesandtheadoptionoftechnologyandartificialintelligenceinukfirms2023/2025-03-24 (search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE]** Scotland BICS (September 2025): 26.7% of businesses used AI, up from 14.0% in September 2023. Most adopters bought external or ready-to-use AI software, though in-house development was growing. The main reason for using AI was improving operations (53.6%). The main reasons for delay were lack of in-house AI expertise (14.1%) and difficulty identifying use cases (10.7%). Scottish Government, Scottish Economic Bulletin December 2025 https://www.gov.scot/publications/scottish-economic-bulletin-december-2025/pages/6/ ; BICS Scotland wave pages, e.g. https://www.gov.scot/publications/bics-weighted-scotland-estimates-data-to-wave-165/pages/artificial-intelligence/ (search summary only. Scotland only, not UK.)
- **[EVIDENCE]** DSIT AI Adoption Research, wave 1, was run by IFF Research and Technopolis: 3,500 UK businesses by telephone, 12 February to 2 May 2025, plus 100 qualitative interviews. AI use was 16% overall: 14% of micro businesses, 23% of medium and 36% of large. DSIT called adoption modest. https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6960f3924343a0da370869ba/AI_Adoption_Research_Report.pdf (search summary only)
- **[EVIDENCE]** DSIT AI Adoption Survey 2026 (published 29 October 2026): 32% of UK businesses used at least one AI technology, against 16% in 2025, with larger firms at 52%. Method: CATI, 7 January to 21 April 2026, 3,503 interviews. I did not obtain the micro-firm figure or the 2026 barrier ranking. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-adoption-survey-2026/ai-adoption-survey-report-2026-executive-summary ; full report https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6ae202189bca21f1c5036e99/artificial-intelligence-adoption-research-report-2026.pdf (search summary only)
- **Note on UK inconsistency.** In mid-2026 the ONS (BICS, about 29% of all firms, 35% of 10+) and DSIT (32%) roughly agree, despite different methods. DSIT doubled from 16% to 32% in one year. ONS shows a slower rise (+8 points June 2025 to June 2026). The two use different questions and bases, and I could not reconcile them without the documents.

4. Official statistics: European Union (Eurostat)

- **[EVIDENCE]** Eurostat, "Use of artificial intelligence in enterprises" (ICT usage survey; data extracted December 2025):
    - In 2025, 20.0% of EU enterprises with 10+ employees used at least one AI technology, up from 13.5% in 2024.
    - By size in 2025: small (10-49) 17.0%, medium (50-249) 30.4%, large (250+) 55.0%.
    - The most common use was analysing written language (11.8% of enterprises).

  https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/index.php/Use_of_artificial_intelligence_in_enterprises (search summary only)
- **[EVIDENCE, second-hand]** For 2024, small-enterprise use was 11.2% (cited from Eurostat in a secondary paper, not checked against the table). That implies roughly +6 points for small firms in one year (my arithmetic).
- **[EVIDENCE] The size gap widened in 2025 (gap-fill pass).** The 2025 figures were released on 11 December 2025 (Eurostat release code DDN-20251211-2, per secondary

citations). For 2024, secondary sources give about 11% small, 21% medium and 41% large. So large enterprises rose about 14 points in a year and small ones about 6. The large-to-small ratio is about 3.2 to 1 (55.0% vs 17.0%). EU-wide AI adoption is growing fastest where firms are already biggest. Eurostat Statistics Explained https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/index.php/Use_of_artificial_intelligence_in_enterprises (search extract); 2024 split and release code via https://ioplus.nl/en/posts/ai-usage-soars-in-european-companies and https://ai.bcci.bg/en/news/ai-adoption-gap-bulgaria-eu-eurostat-2025 (search extract, secondary). The 2024 split should be checked against the Eurostat table (isoc_eb_ai).

4b. OECD: Generative AI and the SME workforce (December 2025)

- **[EVIDENCE] (gap-fill pass)** The OECD surveyed more than 5,000 SMEs in Austria, Canada, Germany, Ireland, Japan, Korea and the UK in late 2024. The report was published in December 2025. OECD, Generative AI and the SME Workforce https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/generative-ai-and-the-sme-workforce_2d08b99d-en.html (search extract). Findings:
  - **Adoption.** About 31% of SMEs use generative AI. This ranges from 24% in Japan to 39% in Germany.
  - **Self-reported effects.** 65% of users say it raised employee performance. 83% report no effect on staffing needs. 9% report a decrease and 6% an increase.
  - **Barriers among non-adopters.** Poor fit with their work 57%, copyright or regulatory concerns 54%, worries about data fed into models 52%, lack of employee skills 50%.
  - **Preparation.** 86% of SMEs hold neutral or positive views, and only 2% prohibit use. But a third or fewer of adopting SMEs have trained staff, set internal guidelines or reviewed legal issues.
- **Relevance to the thesis.** "Poor fit with our work" is again the top barrier, as in the ONS, Fed and DSIT data. Process documentation and shared context do not appear among the barriers reported. The low rates of training and guidelines among adopters fit the "use without transformation" pattern: tools arrive, but the organisation around them does not change.
- **Method caveat.** The summary I saw gives no sampling frame or response rate. Seven high-income countries only. Fieldwork was late 2024, before agentic tools were widely available.
- **Method note.** Eurostat's headline series excludes firms under 10 employees, which are the large majority of EU businesses. It counts specific named AI technologies rather than "any AI tool". Statements like "a fifth of EU businesses use AI" therefore say nothing about micro firms.

5. Cross-country executive panel

- **[EVIDENCE]** NBER Working Paper 34836, "Firm Data on AI" (Yotzov, Barrero, Bloom and co-authors; February 2026, revised March 2026):
  - Sample: almost 6,000 CFOs, CEOs and executives from stratified firm samples in the US, UK, Germany and Australia, drawn from central-bank and Fed business panels including the UK Decision Maker Panel and the Atlanta Fed survey.
  - 69% of firms use AI, with use higher at younger and more productive firms. Executives who use AI average about 1.5 hours a week.
  - More than 80% of firms report no impact yet on employment or productivity.
  - Expectations over three years: productivity +1.4%, output +0.8%, employment -0.7%.

https://www.nber.org/papers/w34836 ; PDF https://wfhresearch.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/03/Firm-Data-on-AI-March-2026.pdf (search summary only. Working paper, not peer reviewed.)

    - Relevance: these panels skew toward established firms large enough to have a CFO, so 69% is not an SMB figure. It still shows that even a random-ish executive panel gets far higher "use" than BTOS. The likely reason is that the question captures any use by the firm, including personal use by the executive.

6. Membership and vendor surveys

- **[EVIDENCE (membership survey, response-rate unknown)]** NFIB Research Center, Small Business and Technology Survey (released 25 June 2025). The survey was emailed to a random sample of 20,000 owners from NFIB's membership database and fielded 6-31 March 2025.

    - 24% of small employers used AI technologies (examples given: ChatGPT, Copilot, Grammarly, Canva) and 76% did not.
    - By size (secondary summary): 21% of firms under 10 employees vs 48% of firms over 50.
    - 98% of AI users reported no change in employee numbers.
    - Planned or current uses: communications 29%, marketing 27%.
    - 75% of non-users did not plan to start within 12 months (secondary summary).

  https://www.nfib.com/?p=38888 ; https://smallbiztrends.com/new-nfib-report-reveals-how-small-businesses-harness-tech-and-ai/ (search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: business-association survey with a polling firm, n and method not obtained)]** US Chamber of Commerce Technology Engagement Center with Teneo Research, 2025 edition: 58% of small businesses say they use generative AI, up from 40% (2024) and 23% (2023). The widely shared "98% of small businesses use AI-enabled tools" comes from the 2024 edition. It counts any software with AI features, not deliberate AI use. https://www.uschamber.com/technology/the-impact-of-technology-on-u-s-small-business (search summary only. Sample size and fieldwork dates not found.)

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey, n=540, self-selected panel)]** Thryv (an SMB software vendor), July 2025: "current usage" rose from 39% (2024) to 55% (2025), which Thryv headlined as a "41% surge". n=540 decision-makers, fieldwork 4-14 May 2025. Eligibility: 1-100 employees, revenue $100k to $9.9m, in business 1+ years. Fieldwork firm, weighting and margin of error not found. https://investor.thryv.com/news/news-details/2025/AI-Adoption-Among-Small-Businesses-Surges-41-in-2025-According-to-New-Survey-from-Thryv/ (search summary only)

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: sample is the sponsor's own programme participants)]** Goldman Sachs 10,000 Small Businesses Voices, run by Babson College and David Binder Research:

    - 68% of owners using AI (announced September 2025), up from 51% in 2023.
    - January 27 to February 4, 2026 wave (n=1,256 programme participants): 76% currently use AI and 88% say they need more training to implement it.
    - October 2025 wave (n=1,471): 94% of AI users report a positive impact.

https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20260317141697/en/Survey-Small-Businesses-Embrace-AI-But-Need-Training-and-Support-to-Fully-Harness-It ; https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20251028464955/en/Small-Business-Owners-Plan-to-Grow-Bullish-on-AI-Productivity-Despite-Concerns-Over-Government-Shutdown ; Fox Business on the 68% https://foxbusiness.com/economy/small-business-ai-adoption-jumps-68-owners-plan-significant-workforce-growth-2025 (search summary only)

- **[OPINION / EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey, global n not found)]** Salesforce SMB Trends (2024-25 editions): 75% of SMBs say they are experimenting with or have implemented AI. Regional cuts reach 87% (UAE) and 93% of Indian SMBs "using AI". The only sample size I found was a supplementary Thailand survey of 100 leaders, fielded 8-13 November 2024. Salesforce sells AI products to SMBs. https://www.techedt.com/salesforce-report-87-of-singapore-smbs-using-ai-see-revenue-growth ; https://nationthailand.com/business/economy/40049212 (search summary only)
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: survey by a small-business network, n not obtained)]** Enterprise Nation / Strand Partners (UK, 2026): only 21% of small businesses use AI regularly, and 6% have embedded it into daily work across the business. https://www.smeweb.com/?p=23334 (search summary only. The link between this URL and the figures is probable, not confirmed.)
- **Not obtained:** Intuit QuickBooks, Constant Contact and Microsoft/LinkedIn Work Trend Index SMB figures. The search budget ran out before these.

7. Why the numbers differ (synthesis)

[OPINION, my analysis from the method details above] Six factors explain most of the gap between about 18% (BTOS) and about 76% (Goldman 10KSB).

1. **Definition of "use".**
    - BTOS before November 2025: "used AI in producing goods or services". This deliberately excluded drafting emails.
    - BTOS after: any business function, in the last two weeks.
    - NFIB names ChatGPT, Grammarly and Canva as examples.
    - The 2024 Chamber "98%" counts any AI-enabled software.
    - Salesforce counts "experimenting".

    Each step down that ladder adds users without any change in behaviour.
2. **Who answers, and about whom.** BTOS asks the business about its own use. The SBCS asks whether "the business or its employees" use AI, which captures an employee's personal ChatGPT use. Executive panels ask leaders, who are heavy personal users.
3. **Reference period.** BTOS asks about the last two weeks. Most vendor surveys have no window or ask about "currently". A two-week window undercounts occasional users. Ramp argues this point and has a commercial interest in the higher figure.
4. **Sample frame.** BTOS draws from the Census business register, which includes many non-tech, low-margin micro firms. NFIB uses its membership. The SBCS recruits through partner organisations. Thryv and Salesforce use opt-in online panels with revenue floors ($100k minimum for Thryv). Goldman samples graduates of its own growth programme. Ramp's 46.6% counts card and bill-pay customers of a fintech, by construction tech-forward.

5. **Self-selection and topic salience.** A survey announced as being about AI and technology attracts owners interested in AI. Official surveys bury the AI question among routine questions.

6. **Sponsor incentive.** Every high-end figure comes from an organisation that sells AI products to SMBs (Salesforce, Thryv, Intuit) or runs a programme it wants to show working (Goldman 10KSB). That does not make the numbers false. It does mean they were not designed to estimate prevalence.

The ladder, read together. On the most permissive definitions, about half or more of US small employers touch AI somewhere. About 18-24% of US firms say the business used AI in some function in the last two weeks. Roughly 3% of employer firms are "fully integrated" (7% of the 46% of users in the SBCS). That 3% is the nearest official-data proxy for "AI-native" among SMBs, and it is a self-assessment.

8. Constraints on SMB adoption (what official data say)

- **[EVIDENCE]** UK 2023: use-case identification 39%, cost 21%, skills 16% (ONS, March 2025, link above). Scotland 2025: expertise 14.1%, use cases 10.7%.
- **[EVIDENCE]** US SBCS: among firms with no plans, over half say AI is "not applicable" and 30% "prefer not to use it" (link above).
- **[EVIDENCE (weak, programme panel)]** Goldman 10KSB 2026: 88% of owners say they need more training to implement AI (link above).
- **Gap:** I found no official survey item that asks about undocumented processes, data quality or lack of a shared data layer as barriers. The thesis's specific mechanism ("nobody can describe the real workflow; no shared context") is not measured in any official SMB survey I located. "Can't identify a use case" is the nearest proxy. It is compatible with the thesis, since you can't spot a use case for a workflow you haven't described, but it is equally compatible with a simpler reading: for many small firms there isn't one yet.

9. Implementation costs, failure and abandonment, who implements (gap-fill pass, search extracts only)

Context from the first pass:

- **[EVIDENCE, indirect]** The typical SMB adoption route is buying off-the-shelf AI software (Scotland BICS), and the most-cited uses are communications and marketing (NFIB 29% and 27%). Per-seat SaaS and assistant subscriptions are therefore likely to be the dominant cost, not bespoke builds. The spending data below are consistent with this.
- **[EVIDENCE, indirect]** "Abandonment" is better proxied in official data by the share stuck at "experimenting" (about half of SBCS AI users) than by project-failure rates. Widely quoted failure rates (for example "95% of pilots fail") come from enterprise studies and should not be transferred to SMBs. See tracks 3 and 5.

9a. What SMBs actually spend on AI. No official statistic exists. The best available figures are lender and fintech surveys or card data. They agree that typical spend is small, tens to a few hundred dollars or pounds a month.

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: lender survey, n=241, 10-14 April 2026)]** Clarify Capital, a small-business lending platform. Average annual spend on AI tools, services and initiatives was $10,600, about $880 a month. A few large spenders pull the mean up, so the median is far lower (not obtained). https://clarifycapital.com/small-business-ai-spending (search extract)

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: lender survey, n=363, July 2026)]** A later Clarify Capital wave: 71% of small businesses now pay for AI, against 41% a year earlier. The average monthly bill rose 343%. 59% have no set AI budget. Same URL (search extract; whether the April and July waves share the URL is unconfirmed).
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: card-provider data, method not seen)]** Capital on Tap (UK business credit cards): mean AI spend per small business rose from £93 to £288 between Q2 2024 and Q2 2026. This is reported via secondary coverage. It is probably card-transaction data, but I could not confirm that. https://ppc.land/one-in-three-small-business-owners-raided-personal-savings-to-pay-for-ai/ (search extract, secondary)
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: spend-management vendor data)]** Spendesk: UK and European SMB customers' average AI tool bill was about €160 a month per company in 2024, up fivefold in two years. Spendesk customers only. https://ffnews.com/blog/2024/12/13/spending-on-ai-tools-by-uk-smbs-grows-fivefold-in-past-two-years-according-to-spendesk-data (search extract)
- **[DO NOT CITE yet]** A "median of about $30 a month" and "17.7% of small businesses had bought an AI tool by end-2025" are attributed in secondary blogs to the JPMorganChase Institute. Two targeted searches failed to find the Institute report. Treat as unverified until located on jpmorganchase.com/institute.
- **[OPINION (vendor and agency marketing, weak)]** "AI automation agency" price lists cluster around $1,500 to $25,000 upfront for small-business builds, plus $50 to $2,000 a month to run them. Retainers are quoted at $500 to $3,500 a month for one or two workflows, and agencies serving larger clients quote $10k-$50k setup and $3k-$15k monthly. These come from agencies that sell the service, and the low ends differ by about an order of magnitude. Examples: https://www.solulab.com/ai-automation-cost-for-small-businesses/, https://taskip.net/ai-automation-agency-pricing/, https://aibusiness.vc/solo/how-to-charge-ai-automation-services (search extracts). No Upwork or Fiverr category rate data was found.
- **Reading the cost evidence together.** Measured spend (about £100-£300 or €160 a month on average, with a third or more spending little or nothing) is one to two orders of magnitude below what agencies quote for a bespoke automation build. That fits the adoption data: most SMBs buy subscriptions and never commission a build. A 10-person firm that hires an agency for a shared-context, agentic setup is spending in a band that almost no survey respondents report.

9b. Abandonment and failure. There is no credible SMB AI failure or abandonment rate. I found no survey with a stated method that asks small firms whether they tried AI and stopped, or whether a specific project failed.

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: insurer survey, n=1,500, April 2025)]** NEXT Insurance reported small-business AI use falling from 42% (2024) to 28% (2025), with 58% saying they do not plan to use AI at all. Cost and complexity were the main reasons given. This conflicts with the US Chamber's 58% generative AI use for 2025, and with every official series, which rose. It is better read as a measurement artefact (different samples and wording) than as evidence of abandonment. https://stacker.com/stories/small-business/small-business-ai-adoption-declines-just-28 (search extract, syndicated copy of NEXT's release)
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: sponsor-programme panel)]** Goldman Sachs 10KSB, March 2026: more than three-quarters of owners use AI to some degree, but only 14% have embedded it across core operations. This is a depth gap, not an abandonment rate. Search extract via https://fortune.com/2026/03/18/small-business-ai-slow-integration-across-operations/.
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: lender survey, n=942, 7-9 April 2026)]** Bluevine: 74% of SMBs use or test AI tools. Only 22% are completely confident AI can handle routine tasks on its own. 48%

of adopters save at least four hours a week. https://www.bluevine.com/newsroom/bluevine-study-shows-ai-is-saving-nearly-half-of-smbs-4-hours-a-week (search extract)

- **Bottom line.** Plainly: no one has measured SMB AI abandonment. The SBCS "experimenting" share (about half of users) and the Goldman 14% "embedded" figure show many SMBs are stuck at shallow use. That is not the same as having tried and failed.

9c. Who implements for SMBs. The evidence points to MSPs as the channel SMBs expect to help, and MSPs mostly not yet able to.

- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey of its MSP customers, n>1,000)]** Kaseya, State of the MSP report (2025-26 edition; the year label differs between sources): 48% of MSPs rank AI and automation as their clients' top need, but only 13% generate meaningful revenue from AI services. https://www.itpro.com/technology/artificial-intelligence/ai-demand-soars-as-traditional-deal-sizes-shrink-kaseya-reports ; Kaseya page https://www.kaseya.com/?p=27349 (search extracts)
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: vendor survey, n>1,000 MSPs, 2025)]** OpenText Cybersecurity: 92% of MSPs report growth from client interest in AI, but only about half feel ready to guide SMBs in deploying AI tools. https://s23.q4cdn.com/197378439/files/doc_news/OpenText-Cybersecurity-Finds-92-of-Managed-Service-Providers-See-AI-Driven-Growth-But-Readiness-Gap-Widens-2025.pdf (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE (weak: trade association survey, n=1,042 channel executives, December 2024)]** GTIA (formerly CompTIA Community), State of the Channel 2025: AI tool adoption and cybersecurity demand tied as the top-ranked health drivers for the IT channel, at 49% each. An older CompTIA figure put firms offering automation services, including AI, at 25%. https://businessof.tech/2025/01/06/2025-optimism-abounds-msps-and-small-businesses-double-down-on-growth-tech-and-staying-ahead-of-ai-threats/ (search extract, secondary)
- **[OPINION]** The "AI automation agency" market is visible mainly through agency marketing and course-sellers ("how to charge $2.5K-$15K per project"). I found no independent measure of its size or of how many SMBs use one.
- **Implication.** The MSP data back one part of the thesis: the people SMBs would turn to for implementation say they lack the skills. But it is a supply-side readiness gap (in the channel), not a gap inside the SMB.

9d. Field-experiment evidence on SMBs (the strongest causal evidence found)

- **[EVIDENCE: randomised field experiment, peer-reviewed]** Otis, Clarke, Delecourt, Holtz and Koning, "The Uneven Impact of Generative AI on Entrepreneurial Performance", Management Science (published 2025). 640 Kenyan entrepreneurs over five months were randomly given either a GPT-4 business mentor on WhatsApp or a standard business guide. They found no detectable average effect on performance. Entrepreneurs who were high performers at baseline gained just over 15%, and low performers did about 8% worse (an earlier version gave about 20% and 10%). The gap came from which advice owners chose and how they applied it, not from the advice itself. Low performers asked for help with harder problems. https://pubsonline.informs.org/doi/10.1287/mnsc.2024.06909 ; working paper https://escholarship.org/uc/item/0fb001r8 (search extract)
- **Relevance.** This is the best causal evidence that small-firm AI value depends on the owner's existing capability, a kind of readiness. But the readiness is managerial judgement, not workflow documentation or shared context. Context: very small firms in Kenya, an advice tool not an agent, 2023-24.

10. What "AI-native" plausibly means for a 10-person firm

- **[EVIDENCE]** On the most generous official self-assessment, "fully integrated" AI applies to about 7% of US small-employer AI users, about 3% of all employer firms (SBCS 2026). ONS shows adoption widening, not deepening, with about 1.6 tools per adopter (unverified figure).
- **[EVIDENCE]** Micro firms are close to the average on breadth (ONS 0-9: 28% vs 29% all). The Fed note finds the smallest firms adopt more than size predicts. NBER w34836 finds use higher at younger firms. Taken together, the plausible AI-native SMB is a young, small firm that started with AI tools, not an established 10-person firm that converted.
- **[OPINION]** If "AI-native" means "humans and agents read from and write to one shared business context", then official data cannot measure it, and the closest proxy (about 3% fully integrated) is a self-assessment with no definition behind it. I found no documented, numbers-backed case study of a 10-person firm running that way. That was a search-budget limitation, not proof that none exist. Open question 1 below.
- **[OPINION (vendor case studies, weak)] Gap-fill pass, small-firm case studies.** One targeted search found only vendor-published cases:
  - A London three-partner accountancy paid £449 a month for an AI assistant and reported 12 admin hours saved a week. https://www.softomatesolutions.com/blog/case-study-ai-pa-accountancy-firm-uk/ (search extract)
  - A 14-person firm in Rennes invested €26,000 (excluding VAT) in an AI tool integrated with its production software, plus €500 a month in API costs. No measured outcome was found. https://kolonell.com/en/blog/ai-document-processing-accounting-firm-cost-2026 (search extract)

  None is independent, and none describes humans and agents sharing one business context. A vendor-adjacent analysis notes that firms of about 50-200 people publish almost no AI outcome data. It also notes that hours freed on hourly-billed work are not revenue unless the capacity is sold or costs cut. https://www.codebridge.tech/articles/ai-case-studies-accounting-firms (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE, lead not read]** The Journal of Accountancy (August 2025) reports a study combining a survey of 277 accountants with transaction data from 79 small and midsize firms using AI accounting software. It is the closest thing found to measured small-firm outcomes. https://www.journalofaccountancy.com/news/2025/aug/calculating-ais-impact-on-cpas-new-study-quantifies-time-savings/ (search extract; the underlying paper and its numbers were not obtained)
- **Updated conclusion.** After a targeted search, a 10-person "AI-native" firm documented with independent numbers still does not appear in the public record. What exists is vendor case studies of single-tool deployments costing a few hundred pounds a month (or a one-off €26k) and saving roughly 10 hours a week.

Viral statistics traced

- **"98% of small businesses use AI"**. Origin: US Chamber of Commerce / Teneo, "Impact of Technology on U.S. Small Business", 2024 edition (September 2024). It counts businesses using any tool with AI features (for example, software with built-in AI), not deliberate AI adoption. Aggregators recirculate it next to the 2025 edition's 58% "use generative AI".

Solidity: low as an adoption measure, since it measures the software market, not behaviour. https://www.uschamber.com/technology/the-impact-of-technology-on-u-s-small-business

- **"AI adoption among small businesses surged 41%"**. Origin: Thryv press release, July 2025. The 41% is relative growth from 39% to 55% in a 540-person vendor panel with a $100k revenue floor. Readers often take it as "41% of small businesses use AI". Solidity: weak. https://investor.thryv.com/news/news-details/2025/AI-Adoption-Among-Small-Businesses-Surges-41-in-2025-According-to-New-Survey-from-Thryv/
- **"Census shows AI adoption doubled to 18%"**. Origin: the BTOS question change of 17 November 2025. The jump is mostly a wording effect (Census itself notes a level shift). Solidity: the 17-18% level is solid as a measure under the new wording. The doubling is not a behavioural trend. https://ramp.com/data/ai-index-january-2026 ; https://www.census.gov/hfp/btos/downloads/AI%20Question%20Wording%20Updates.pdf
- **"AI adoption is declining at large companies (Census)"** (Tom's Hardware, Gizmodo, September 2025). Origin: short-run moves in the old-wording BTOS series for large firms, on the biweekly two-week window. Critics argued the window is too narrow to infer a trend. Solidity: weak as a trend claim, and superseded by the wording change. https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/ai-adoption-rate-is-declining-among-large-companies-us-census-bureau-claims-fewer-businesses-are-using-ai-tools
- **"68% / 76% of small businesses use AI" (Goldman Sachs)**. Origin: Goldman Sachs 10,000 Small Businesses Voices, which surveys alumni of Goldman's own business-education programme (n about 1,200-1,500 per wave). News coverage reports it as "small businesses" in general. Solidity: valid for that population only. https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20260317141697/en/Survey-Small-Businesses-Embrace-AI-But-Need-Training-and-Support-to-Fully-Harness-It

Strongest counter-evidence (against the thesis and against the mainstream reading of this track)

Against the thesis ("AI fails because the business isn't ready"):

- **Many SMBs are not failing at AI. They are declining it, and say why.** In the Fed SBCS, a third of US employer firms have no plans to use AI. More than half of those say it is not applicable and 30% prefer not to. That is a judgement, not a readiness gap. https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/2026-report-on-employer-firms
- **The documented barriers are use-case identification, skills and cost, not process documentation or shared context** (ONS 2023: 39% / 16% / 21%). The thesis's mechanism is untested in official SMB data. https://www.ons.gov.uk/economy/economicoutputandproductivity/productivitymeasures/articles/managementpracticesandtheadoptionoftechnologyandartificialintelligenceinukfirms2023/2025-03-24
- **For most SMBs there is no transformation project to fail.** Adoption is buying ready-made tools (Scotland BICS) for writing and marketing (NFIB). "The tech is the easy part" is literally true here, but the hard part that follows is often not attempted at all, rather than attempted and failed.
- **Cross-country SME data agree (gap-fill pass).** OECD (more than 5,000 SMEs, seven countries): the top barrier among non-adopters is poor fit with their work (57%), and 83% of adopters report no effect on staffing. https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/generative-ai-and-the-sme-workforce_2d08b99d-en.html

- **The one SMB randomised experiment shows the binding constraint is the owner's judgement, not documentation.** In Otis et al. (Kenya, n=640), GPT-4 advice helped strong performers and hurt weak ones, with no average effect. https://pubsonline.informs.org/doi/10.1287/mnsc.2024.06909
- **The few impact measures available are positive or neutral, not failure.** 71% of SBCS AI users report higher productivity. 94% of Goldman 10KSB users report positive impact (weak panel). 98% of NFIB users report no headcount change. Self-reports skew positive, but there is no SMB evidence of widespread failed AI projects.

Against the mainstream reading ("SMBs are rapidly adopting AI"):

- Official measures sit at about a fifth to a third of firms. "Fully integrated" sits around 3% of US employer firms. UK depth of use is flat while breadth triples. The vendor-survey consensus of "most SMBs use AI" rests on permissive definitions and self-selected panels.
- The single largest one-period jump in the US official series (about 10% to about 17%) is a questionnaire change.

Against the "micro firms lag" assumption:

- ONS puts 0-9 employee firms at 28% vs 29% overall. The Fed note says the smallest firms over-perform their size. NFIB, by contrast, shows a steep gradient (21% vs 48%). The evidence on micro firms conflicts.

Open questions

1. Are there any independent, numbers-backed case studies of 5-15 person firms where staff and agents share one stored business context (cost, time to build, what broke)? One targeted search found only vendor single-tool cases. Still the highest priority.
2. What do SMB AI implementations cost, split between subscriptions, integration and outside help? Lender and card data now suggest average subscription spend of roughly £100-£300 a month. Nothing measures integration or outside-help spend. Upwork/Fiverr category data and UK BICS in-house vs purchased questions remain unchecked.
3. Is there any SMB-specific measure of AI abandonment with a stated method? Still none found. The SF Fed's July 2026 qualitative SBCS brief is the best lead.
4. Who implements for SMBs? MSP surveys (Kaseya, OpenText, GTIA) show demand but low MSP readiness and revenue. The size of the "AI automation agency" market and the share of SMBs using freelancers remain unmeasured.
5. What does DSIT 2026 say about micro-firm adoption and barriers? The full report was published 29 October 2026 and could not be fetched.
6. What is the latest BTOS figure under the new wording, by firm size? The August to September 2026 readings of 23-24% are unverified.
7. Does CES-WP-26-25 show whether small firms use AI in more than one business function? This would be the best US depth measure.
8. OECD SME reports (for example its 2025 survey work on generative AI and SMEs) and Intuit QuickBooks, Constant Contact and Microsoft/LinkedIn surveys: not obtained.

What's genuinely uncertain

- **The true level of SMB AI use.** Defensible figures run from about 14% to about 46% depending on definition. Neither end is wrong. They measure different things.

- **Whether the BTOS-SBCS gap (about 18-20% vs 46%) is mostly definition** (business use in the last two weeks vs the business "or its employees" ever using it) **or mostly sample frame.** Probably both. No study I found decomposes it.
- **Whether micro firms lag or not.** Official UK data say barely. NFIB and Census size bands say yes.
- **Whether the DSIT jump from 16% to 32% in a year is real behaviour or method.** Same contractor model and CATI, but I could not compare questionnaires.
- **Whether "fully integrated" (SBCS 7% of users) means anything close to AI-native.** It is a self-assessment with no definition behind it.
- **Every number in this file is unverified on its source page** (see header).

Numbers for the facts file

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
~10% to ~17% (corrected in verification)	US firms using AI, before vs after BTOS question change (17 Nov 2025)	Ramp AI Index; Census wording note	https://ramp.com/data/ai-index-january-2026	14 Jan 2026	Level shift is a wording artefact. Search-summary only
~18%	US firms using AI, year-end 2025 (new wording)	Fed FEDS Note	https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/monitoring-ai-adoption-in-the-u-s-economy-20260403.html	3 Apr 2026	Official staff analysis of BTOS. Search-summary only
~19.8%	US firms using AI, period ending 3 May 2026	Census Bureau story	https://census.gov/library/stories/2026/05/ai-use-businesses.html	May 2026	Official. Search-summary only
<20%	US firms with 1-4 employees using AI (ceiling, not point)	Census Bureau story	https://census.gov/library/stories/2026/05/ai-use-businesses.html	May 2026	Census publishes as a band
46%	US small employer firms whose business or employees use AI	Fed SBCS 2026 Report on Employer Firms	https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/2026-report-on-employer-firms	Mar 2026 (fieldwork Sep-Nov 2025)	Convenience sample, weighted. Includes employees' use
7%	Share of SBCS AI-using firms "fully integrated" (~3% of all employer firms, my arithmetic)	Fed SBCS 2026	https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/2026-report-on-employer-firms	Mar 2026	Self-assessed. Search-summary only
71%	SBCS AI users reporting higher productivity	Fed SBCS 2026; Cook speech	https://www.federalreserve.gov/newsevents/speech/cook20260624a.htm	24 Jun 2026	Self-report
>50% / 30%	Of SBCS firms with no AI plans: "not applicable" / "prefer not to use"	Fed SBCS 2026	https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/2026-report-on-employer-firms	Mar 2026	Search-summary only
24%	US small employers using AI (21% of <10 employees; 48% of >50)	NFIB Small Business and Technology Survey	https://www.nfib.com/?p=38888	25 Jun 2025	Random draw of 20,000 members by email. Size split from secondary summary
98%	NFIB AI users reporting no change in employee numbers	NFIB	https://www.nfib.com/?p=38888	25 Jun 2025	Search-summary only
58%		US Chamber / Teneo 2025		2025	n and method not found

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
	US small businesses saying they use generative AI		https://www.uschamber.com/technology/the-impact-of-technology-on-u-s-small-business		
98%	US small businesses using any AI-enabled tool	US Chamber 2024 edition	https://www.uschamber.com/technology/the-impact-of-technology-on-u-s-small-business	Sep 2024	Measures software features, not adoption. Do not cite as adoption
55% (from 39%)	Small businesses "currently using" AI	Thryv	https://investor.thryv.com/news/news-details/2025/AI-Adoption-Among-Small-Businesses-Surges-41-in-2025-According-to-New-Survey-from-Thryv/	17 Jul 2025	Vendor, n=540, revenue floor $100k
76%	Goldman 10KSB participants using AI	Goldman Sachs 10KSB Voices (Babson / David Binder)	https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20260317141697/en/Survey-Small-Businesses-Embrace-AI-But-Need-Training-and-Support-to-Fully-Harness-It	17 Mar 2026	n=1,256 programme alumni. Not representative
46.6%	US businesses with paid AI spend on Ramp	Ramp AI Index	https://ramp.com/data/ai-index-january-2026	14 Jan 2026	Ramp customers only, tech-forward
69%	Firms using AI, executive panels in US/UK/DE/AU	NBER w34836	https://www.nber.org/papers/w34836	Feb/Mar 2026	n about 6,000. Working paper
>80%	Firms in that panel reporting no AI impact on employment or productivity	NBER w34836	https://www.nber.org/papers/w34836	Feb/Mar 2026	Search-summary only
~12% to ~35%	UK firms with 10+ employees using AI, late 2023 to mid-2026	ONS AI in UK businesses 2023-2026	https://www.ons.gov.uk/businessindustryandtrade/business/businessservices/articles/artificialintelligenceinukbusinesses/2023to2026	20 Jul 2026	Official. Search-summary only
29% / 28% / 49%	UK firms using AI, June 2026: all / 0-9 employees / 250+	ONS (BICS)	same as above	Jul 2026	Official. Search-summary only
1.6	AI tools per UK adopter	TNW on ONS	https://thenextweb.com/news/uk-ai-adoption-widening-not-deepening-ons-2026	Jul 2026	Not confirmed in ONS tables
4%	UK AI-using firms reporting headcount fell due to AI	ONS BICS	https://www.ons.gov.uk/businessindustryandtrade/business/businessservices/bulletins/businessinsightsandimpactontheukeconomy/8january2026	8 Jan 2026	Attribution to bulletin inferred
39% / 21% / 16%	UK barriers 2023: use cases / cost / skills	ONS management practices article	https://www.ons.gov.uk/economy/economicoutputandproductivity/productivitymeasures/articles/managementpracticesandtheadoptionoftechnologyandartificialintelligenceinukfirms2023/2025-03-24	24 Mar 2025	Official. Search-summary only
16% overall; 14% micro	UK businesses using AI, 2025	DSIT AI Adoption Research (IFF / Technopolis, n=3,500 CATI)	https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6960f3924343a0da370869ba/AI_Adoption_Research_Report.pdf	2025 (pub. ~Jan 2026)	Official-commissioned. Search-summary only
32% (vs 16%)	UK businesses using at least one AI technology, 2026	DSIT AI Adoption Survey 2026 (n=3,503 CATI)	https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-adoption-survey-2026/ai-adoption-survey-report-2026-executive-summary	29 Oct 2026	Micro figure not obtained
20.0% (13.5% in 2024)	EU enterprises with 10+ employees using AI, 2025	Eurostat	https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/index.php/Use_of_artificial_intelligence_in_enterprises	Dec 2025	Excludes <10 employees

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
17.0% / 30.4% / 55.0%	EU AI use 2025: small / medium / large	Eurostat	same	Dec 2025	Search-summary only
26.7%	Scottish businesses using AI, Sep 2025 (14.0% Sep 2023)	Scottish Government BICS	https://www.gov.scot/publications/scottish-economic-bulletin-december-2025/pages/6/	Dec 2025	Scotland only
~11% / 21% / 41%	EU AI use 2024: small / medium / large (so +6 vs +14 points to 2025)	Eurostat via secondary	https://ioplus.nl/en/posts/ai-usage-soars-in-european-companies	Dec 2025	Secondary; check isoc_eb_ai table
31% (24% JP to 39% DE)	SMEs using generative AI, 7 OECD countries, late 2024	OECD, Generative AI and the SME Workforce, n>5,000	https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/generative-ai-and-the-sme-workforce_2d08b99d-en.html	Dec 2025	Official IO survey; frame not seen. Search extract
57%	Non-adopting SMEs citing poor fit with their work	OECD, same	same	Dec 2025	Search extract
83% / 9% / 6%	Adopting SMEs: no staffing effect / decrease / increase	OECD, same	same	Dec 2025	Search extract
$10,600/ yr	Mean SMB spend on AI tools, services and initiatives (n=241)	Clarify Capital	https://clarifycapital.com/small-business-ai-spending	Apr 2026	Lender survey; mean skewed by big spenders
71% (from 41%)	SMBs paying for AI (n=363)	Clarify Capital	https://clarifycapital.com/small-business-ai-spending	Jul 2026	Lender survey. Search extract
£93 to £288	Mean AI spend per UK small business, Q2 2024 to Q2 2026	Capital on Tap via PPC Land	https://ppc.land/one-in-three-small-business-owners-raided-personal-savings-to-pay-for-ai/	2026	Card provider; method not seen; secondary
~€160/ month	Average AI tool bill per UK/EU SMB customer, 2024	Spendesk	https://ffnews.com/blog/2024/12/13/spending-on-ai-tools-by-uk-smbs-grows-fivefold-in-past-two-years-according-to-spendesk-data	Dec 2024	Vendor customer data
$1,500-$25,000 + $50-$2,000/ mo	Agency-quoted SMB AI automation build + running cost	Agency blogs	https://www.solulab.com/ai-automation-cost-for-small-businesses/	2025-26	OPINION; sellers' price lists
48% / 13%	MSPs ranking AI as clients' top need / earning meaningful AI revenue	Kaseya State of the MSP (n>1,000)	https://www.itpro.com/technology/artificial-intelligence/ai-demand-soars-as-traditional-deal-sizes-shrink-kaseya-reports	2025-26	Vendor survey of MSPs. Search extract
~50%	MSPs feeling ready to guide SMBs in AI deployment	OpenText (n>1,000 MSPs)	https://s23.q4cdn.com/197378439/files/doc_news/OpenText-Cybersecurity-Finds-92-of-Managed-Service-Providers-See-AI-Driven-Growth-But-Readiness-Gap-Widens-2025.pdf	2025	Vendor survey. Search extract
42% to 28%	SMBs using AI, 2024 to 2025	NEXT Insurance (n=1,500)	https://stacker.com/stories/small-business/small-business-ai-adoption-declines-just-28	Apr 2025	Insurer survey; conflicts with all official series
14%	Goldman 10KSB owners with AI embedded across core operations	Goldman 10KSB via Fortune	https://fortune.com/2026/03/18/small-business-ai-slow-integration-across-operations/	Mar 2026	Programme panel
74% / 22%	SMBs using or testing AI / fully confident AI can do routine tasks alone	Bluevine (n=942)	https://www.bluevine.com/newsroom/bluevine-study-shows-ai-is-saving-nearly-half-of-smbs-4-hours-a-week	Apr 2026	Lender survey
+15% / -8%	Performance effect of GPT-4 mentor on high / low baseline performers;	Otis et al., Management Science (RCT,	https://pubsonline.informs.org/doi/10.1287/mnsc.2024.06909	2025	Peer-reviewed RCT; figures vary by version

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
	average effect not distinguishable from zero	n=640 Kenyan entrepreneurs)			

Verbatim quotes

None. No source page could be fetched in this session (proxy and DNS blocks on all source hosts tried), so no wording could be confirmed. Phrases that appear only in search summaries have been paraphrased above. Candidate quotes to fetch and verify later: Census's description of the level shift in the AI Question Wording Updates PDF; the SBCS 2026 report's sentence on "fully integrated" AI; Ramp's Kharazian on the Census economist's objection.

Sources worth reading in full (ranked, one line each on why)

1. **Fed SBCS, 2026 Report on Employer Firms** https://www.fedsmallbusiness.org/2026-report-on-employer-firms. The only large US small-firm survey that measures depth (experimenting / partial / full) and reasons for non-use.
2. **ONS, Artificial intelligence in UK businesses: 2023 to 2026** https://www.ons.gov.uk/businessindustryandtrade/business/businessservices/articles/artificialintelligenceinukbusinesses/2023to2026. Official breadth vs depth, with size bands including 0-9 employees.
3. **Census BTOS AI Question Wording Updates** https://www.census.gov/hfp/btos/downloads/AI%20Question%20Wording%20Updates.pdf. Needed before citing any US trend across late 2025.
4. **DSIT AI Adoption Survey 2026 full report** https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6ae202189bca21f1c5036e99/artificial-intelligence-adoption-research-report-2026.pdf. 3,503-firm UK survey with micro breakdowns and barriers, published 29 October 2026.
5. **Census CES-WP-26-25, The Microstructure of AI Diffusion** https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2026/adrm/CES-WP-26-25.html. Firm vs function vs task use. Best US source on depth.
6. **NBER w34836, Firm Data on AI** https://www.nber.org/papers/w34836. Cross-country executive panel. High use, little measured impact.
7. **Fed FEDS Note, Monitoring AI Adoption in the U.S. Economy** https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/monitoring-ai-adoption-in-the-u-s-economy-20260403.html. Reconciles BTOS with private data and flags small-firm over-performance.
8. **NFIB Small Business and Technology Survey (June 2025)** https://www.nfib.com/?p=38888. Large owner sample with size gradient and headcount effect.
9. **Eurostat, Use of AI in enterprises** https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/index.php/Use_of_artificial_intelligence_in_enterprises. EU size-class comparison and reasons for non-use.
10. **Ramp AI Index, January 2026** https://ramp.com/data/ai-index-january-2026. Strongest argument that official surveys undercount, written by an interested party.
11. **OECD, Generative AI and the SME Workforce (Dec 2025)** https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/generative-ai-and-the-sme-workforce_2d08b99d-en.html. Seven-country SME survey with barriers, staffing effects and preparation. Best cross-country SME source.
12. **Otis et al., Management Science** https://pubsonline.informs.org/doi/10.1287/mnsc.2024.06909. The only randomised experiment on generative AI in small firms found. Shows heterogeneity by owner capability.

13. **SF Fed, "AI Adoption Among Small Businesses: Qualitative Insights from the SBCS" (July 2026)** https://www.frbsf.org/research-and-insights/publications/community-development-research-briefs/2026/07/ai-adoption-in-small-businesses-2024-sbcs/. Not read. Open-text answers from SBCS respondents. Likely the best official source on why SMBs stop or stall.
14. **AEO, "Main Street AI Paradox" brief** https://aeoworks.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/07/AEO_Main-Street-AI-Paradox_Brief_2025.pdf. Not read. Looks directly relevant to micro-business AI use.